

Chapter 7 — Classroom Management and SEL

25 prompts

Most behaviour problems are routine problems wearing a disguise. These prompts work on the structures — how a transition runs, what you say in the first ten seconds, how a conversation gets repaired afterwards — rather than on the student.

WHAT'S IN HERE

GROUP	PROMPTS	USE WHEN
Routines and transitions	6	The same four minutes lost, every day
Behaviour reset support	5	It went wrong; you want it back
Restorative conversations	4	Repair, not punishment
Social-emotional learning	4	Building it into normal lessons
Morning meetings	3	Openings a shy student can join
Seating and grouping	3	Who sits where, on purpose

WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU START

This chapter has the firmest limit in the book. If a situation involves harm, abuse, or immediate danger, stop and follow your school's safeguarding procedure. Do not work it through with an AI tool. Nothing here is a substitute for that process, and several prompts are written to say so and stop.

Focus on the behaviour and the repair. Nothing here should produce a judgement about a child's character, home life or motivation.

A restorative conversation is not a forced apology. If a draft demands one, change it — several prompts rule it out explicitly.

Keep in-the-moment scripts under fifteen words. Anything longer becomes an audience.

ROUTINES AND TRANSITIONS

CM-001 Design and teach a classroom routine

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The same four minutes disappear every day at the same point.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design a routine for [WHAT – entry, packing up, handing work in, moving to the carpet] in [GRADE].

Class size: [NUMBER]. Room: [DESCRIBE].

What currently happens: [DESCRIBE THE MESS]

Give me:

- The routine as a sequence of steps, one action per step
- The exact words I say to start it, under 10 seconds
- The signal that tells me everyone has finished
- How I teach it in the first week: what I model, what they practise, what I correct
- What I do on day 20 when it starts to slip

Do not build in a reward, a points system, or a competition. The routine should work because it is clear, not because it is incentivised.

Keep it to steps a [GRADE] student can hold in their head.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Can a student hold all the steps at once? Cut one if not.
- Would these words sound like you saying them?

CM-003 Teach an efficient entry routine with an immediate learning start

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The first five minutes are the ones you never get back.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design an entry routine for [GRADE] [SUBJECT] where learning starts before I have finished the register.

Constraints: [DESCRIBE – do they queue outside, arrive from different lessons, need equipment handed out]

Give me:

- What is on the board or on desks before they arrive
- What a student does in their first 60 seconds without being told
- What I do during that time
- How a late arrival joins without disrupting or being announced
- What I do about the student who arrives with nothing

Do not make the opening task new content – it must be startable by a student who missed the last lesson.

Tell me what to change if my room is entered through a single narrow door.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could a student who missed yesterday still start?
- Does the late arrival keep their dignity?

CM-004 Create a calm transition between whole-group and independent work

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The moment the noise doubles and half the class stops working.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design the transition from whole-group teaching to independent work in [GRADE] [SUBJECT].

Give me:

- The exact words, under 15 seconds, one instruction at a time
- The order things happen in – instructions before materials, always
- How students know what to do if they are stuck in the first minute, without queuing at my desk
- What I do in the first 90 seconds, and where I stand
- The signal for a student who needs me, that does not involve a raised hand held for four minutes

A [GRADE] class will do the first thing you say and forget the rest. Write accordingly.

Then tell me the single most common reason this transition fails.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is each instruction one action?
- Are materials handed out after the instructions, not during?

CM-005 Build a materials routine that reduces waiting and lost equipment

Grades K-2, 3-5, 6-8

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Handing out and collecting eats more time than anyone admits.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design a materials routine for [GRADE] [SUBJECT].

What gets distributed: [LIST IT]

Class size: [NUMBER]. Layout: [DESCRIBE]

Give me:

- How materials get to students without me walking to every desk
- Who does what, and how those jobs rotate so they are not a status
- The collection routine, and how I know instantly what is missing
- What happens when something is missing, that does not turn into an investigation
- What I do about the student who never has a pen, without making it a public event

Do not build a system that requires students to pay, replace, or be publicly recorded as having lost something.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is the no-pen student handled quietly?
- Do the jobs rotate, or become a privilege?

CM-006 Plan a dismissal routine that protects safety and learning time

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The last four minutes, which are also the least safe four minutes.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design a dismissal routine for [GRADE].

Context: [WHERE THEY GO NEXT, WHETHER THEY COLLECT BAGS, CORRIDOR OR PLAYGROUND]

Give me:

- When packing up starts, and why not earlier
- The order students leave in, and how that is decided fairly
- The 30-second closing that means the lesson ends rather than stops
- What I do if the bell goes mid-sentence
- How I hold back one student for a word without the class registering it as trouble

I will check anything about supervision, corridors or leaving the site against my school's own procedures.

Do not use leaving early as a reward, or leaving last as a consequence.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Check supervision arrangements against your school's policy.
- Would holding one student back be noticed by the class?

CM-007 Audit a routine using timing, participation and independence evidence

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The routine exists. You are not sure it is earning its place.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this [GRADE] routine: [DESCRIBE IT]

What actually happens: [DESCRIBE, INCLUDING HOW LONG IT TAKES]

Tell me:

- Where the time actually goes, step by step
- Which step needs me, and whether it should
- Where students wait with nothing to do
- Whether a student who joined this term would know what to do
- Whether it depends on my presence, my voice, or my mood on the day
- Whether any part singles a student out

Then tell me:

- The one step to remove
- Whether this routine is worth its time at all

Be blunt about a routine that has become habit rather than function.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Time it honestly next lesson before deciding.
- Does it work when you are tired? That is the real test.

BEHAVIOUR RESET SUPPORT

CM-008 Create a brief private behaviour-reset conversation

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Something needs saying, and it must not become a performance.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Prepare a brief private conversation with a [GRADE] student about a classroom behaviour.

What happened, observably: [DESCRIBE THE BEHAVIOUR – not the student]

What I want: [THE SPECIFIC CHANGE]

Give me:

- What I say in the moment, under 15 words, with no audience
- What I say one-to-one afterwards – opening, the point, the ask
- One question that gives the student a chance to say something I do not know
- How I close so the student can return without a face to save
- Three things NOT to say, and why each makes it worse

Rules:

- Address the behaviour and its effect, never the character
- Do not ask a student to explain themselves in front of others
- Do not require an apology
- Do not speculate about home, mood, or what is going on for them

If what I described suggests harm, danger or a safeguarding concern, stop and tell me to follow my school's process instead.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is the in-the-moment line short enough to say without a pause?
- Is anything here about the child rather than what they did?

CM-009 Write neutral redirection language for a recurring disruption

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

The twelfth time today, and your tone is starting to show.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write redirection language for this recurring [GRADE] classroom behaviour:

[DESCRIBE IT – what happens, how often, in what part of the lesson]

Give me:

- Four redirections, escalating in directness, each under 12 words
- A non-verbal option for the first level
- The exact wording that names the expected action rather than the problem – "pen in your hand" rather than "stop fiddling"
- What I say the fifth time in one lesson, that is not the fourth said louder
- The point at which continuing to redirect is the wrong response, and what replaces it

Rules: no sarcasm, no rhetorical questions, no comparisons to other students, no public countdowns, and nothing that requires the student to respond verbally in front of the class.

Then tell me what the behaviour might be communicating that redirection cannot address.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Say them aloud. Any sarcasm you did not intend?
- Do they name the wanted action rather than the problem?

CM-010 Plan a re-entry routine after a learner leaves the classroom

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

They come back, and how that goes decides the rest of the lesson.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Plan how a [GRADE] student returns to the classroom after leaving it.

Context: [WHY THEY LEFT, HOW LONG, WHERE THEY WENT]

Give me:

- What I say as they come in, under 10 words, that does not restart the incident
- How they rejoin the work without needing a long explanation
- When the conversation about what happened takes place – not now
- What the rest of the class sees, and how I keep it unremarkable
- What I do if they return still upset

Rules:

- Re-entry is not the moment for consequences or a conversation about behaviour
- Do not require the student to apologise before rejoining
- Do not have them stand at the door waiting for permission in front of everyone

I will follow my school's procedures for anything involving where a student went and who supervised them.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does re-entry stay separate from the conversation?
- Would the class notice anything?

CM-011 Create a reset menu that preserves dignity and instructional access

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Options a student can take before things escalate.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a short menu of reset options for [GRADE] students who need a moment.

Room and supervision constraints: [DESCRIBE]

Give me:

- 4-5 options, from smallest to largest – a change of position, a task with hands, a short walk with a purpose
- How a student takes one without asking in front of the class
- How each keeps the student in the room and in the lesson where possible
- What each is not: not a reward, not a punishment, not time out
- How the student returns to work afterwards

Rules:

- Nothing that removes access to the learning
- Nothing visible enough to mark a student out
- Nothing requiring supervision I do not have
- Nothing that can be earned or lost

Then tell me which option is most likely to be misused, and how to handle that without withdrawing it from everyone.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does any option cost the student the lesson?
- Can a student take one privately?

CM-012 Audit a response plan for escalation, shame and inconsistent expectations

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Before the plan is in place for a term.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this [GRADE] behaviour response plan: [PASTE OR DESCRIBE IT]

Tell me:

- Where a step escalates rather than de-escalates
- Anything that makes a student's behaviour visible to the class – a chart, a name on the board, a public warning, a colour change
- Anywhere the response depends on my mood, energy, or how the day has gone
- Where the same behaviour would get different responses from different students, and why that might be happening
- Anything that removes learning as a consequence
- Whether there is a route back for a student who has had a bad day

Then tell me the single step most likely to make a situation worse, and what replaces it.

Be direct about anything that shames a child, whatever it is called.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is anything public that should be private?
- Is there a genuine route back?

RESTORATIVE CONVERSATIONS

CM-002 Prepare a restorative conversation

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Something happened between students, and it needs repair rather than a verdict.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Prepare a restorative conversation between [GRADE] students.

What happened, observably: [DESCRIBE – no names, no interpretation]

Who is involved: [ROLES ONLY, e.g. two students, one affected]

Give me:

- How I open, so nobody arrives expecting a trial
- Neutral questions for each person, in order
- The question that moves it from what happened to what it did to someone
- How the affected student says what they need, without being put on the spot
- How we close, whether or not agreement is reached

Rules – these are not optional:

- No forced apology, and no requirement that anyone accept one
- No requirement that anyone disclose feelings they do not want to share
- Either student may stop, and stopping is not a failure
- I do not determine guilt in this conversation

If what I described involves harm, abuse, bullying or immediate danger, stop and
tell me to follow my school's safeguarding process instead of continuing.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- If it flagged safeguarding, stop and use your school's process.
- Is any question really an accusation?

CM-013 Create questions that explore impact, needs and possible repair

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Questions that open something rather than extract a confession.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Write restorative questions for a [GRADE] situation: [DESCRIBE IT NEUTRALLY]

Give me four sets:

- What happened – factual, without inviting justification
- Who was affected and how
- What is needed now
- What could be different next time

Rules:

- No question beginning "why did you", which produces defence, not reflection
- No question a student can only answer by admitting fault
- Every question answerable by a student who is upset, embarrassed, or monosyllabic
- Include the shorter version of each for a student who cannot manage the full question

Then tell me:

- Which question most often gets a shrug, and what to do with a shrug
- Which question I should skip if the student is not ready

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Any "why did you" left?
- Could an embarrassed student answer these?

CM-014 Build a voluntary repair agreement with a scheduled follow-up

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Something agreed, that both students actually agreed to.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a repair agreement after a restorative conversation between [GRADE] students.

What was discussed: [SUMMARISE – no names]

What was offered: [BY WHOM]

Give me:

- The agreement in the students' own kind of language, not mine
- What each person will do, only where they offered it
- A follow-up date, and who initiates it
- What happens if it does not hold – which is not a punishment
- How the agreement ends, so it is not open forever

Rules:

- Nothing in it that was not voluntarily offered
- No apology as a required item
- No public element – nothing performed in front of the class
- The affected student is not required to forgive, accept, or be satisfied

If either student was not genuinely willing, say so and tell me the agreement should not be written.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Was every item genuinely offered, not extracted?
- Is there an end date?

CM-015 Audit a restorative script for coercion, blame and safeguarding limits

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Restorative language can carry coercion inside it.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this restorative script or plan: [PASTE IT]

Tell me:

- Any question that assigns blame while appearing neutral, quoted
- Anywhere a student is required to apologise, forgive, or say they are fine
- Anywhere disclosure of feelings is compulsory rather than invited
- Anything that would be unsafe if there is a power imbalance between the students
- Anywhere the process continues when a student clearly wants to stop
- Anything that belongs in a safeguarding process rather than a classroom conversation

Then tell me:

- The single most coercive element, however gently worded
- The point at which this should stop being handled by me

Be direct. A script that pressures a child into performing reconciliation is worse than no script.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Act on the power-imbalance flag before running the conversation.
- Where it says stop being yours to handle — take that to your school.

SOCIAL-EMOTIONAL LEARNING

CM-016 Create an age-appropriate lesson on naming and managing emotions

Grades K-2, 3-5, 6-8

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Teaching the vocabulary before it is needed in an argument.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Plan a [MINUTES]-minute [GRADE] lesson on naming and managing emotions.

Give me:

- The emotion vocabulary appropriate for [GRADE], and the words to leave out because they are clinical rather than everyday
- A way in that uses fictional characters or scenarios, never students' own experiences
- One strategy taught properly rather than five mentioned
- Practice using the strategy on a fictional situation
- What students take away that they could use tomorrow

Rules:

- No student is asked to share a personal feeling or experience
- Nothing that asks students to rate, chart or report their own mood publicly
- No language that pathologises ordinary feelings
- This is teaching vocabulary and strategy, not therapy

If any part of what I have asked for belongs with a counsellor rather than a teacher, say so.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is any student required to disclose anything?
- Is the vocabulary everyday, not clinical?

CM-017 Teach a practical strategy for pausing before responding

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

One strategy, taught well enough to be used under pressure.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Teach [GRADE] students one strategy for pausing before responding.

Give me:

- The strategy, in three steps a student can remember when upset
- Why it works, in language a [GRADE] student accepts – not neuroscience
- How I teach it when nobody is upset, which is the only time it can be taught
- Three fictional scenarios to practise on
- The cue I use in the moment that is not "calm down"
- What I say when a student uses it and it does not work

Rules:

- Nothing requiring a student to breathe in a particular way in front of others
- Nothing visible enough to mark a student out as needing it
- The strategy belongs to the student, not to me – they choose to use it

Then tell me what this strategy cannot do, so I do not expect too much of it.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Can a student use it without anyone noticing?
- Is "why it works" believable to a student, or a lecture?

CM-018 Build an empathy activity without requiring personal disclosure

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Empathy work that does not turn into an exercise in exposure.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design a [MINUTES]-minute [GRADE] empathy activity.

Topic or context: [DESCRIBE]

Rules – these define the task:

- Students work with fictional characters or scenarios only
- No student is asked to share a personal experience, feeling, or family circumstance
- No activity where students imagine being someone with a specific identity, disability or circumstance as a simulation
- Nothing that could expose a student's own situation by how they respond

Give me:

- The activity
- The fictional scenarios, written so no student would recognise themselves
- The discussion questions
- What I do if a student volunteers something personal anyway
- The closing that does not require anyone to have been moved

Then tell me what could go wrong with this activity in a class where I do not know everyone's circumstances.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Could a scenario be someone's actual life? Change it if so.
- Do you know what to do if a student discloses?

CM-019 Audit an SEL activity for privacy, culture and clinical overreach

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

SEL work goes wrong quietly, and usually with good intentions.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this [GRADE] SEL activity: [PASTE OR DESCRIBE IT]

Tell me:

- Anywhere a student is asked or nudged to disclose something personal
- Anywhere a response would reveal a student's home, family or circumstances to the class
- Anything assuming a family shape, faith, culture or way of expressing emotion
- Anything crossing from teaching into counselling or therapy
- Any use of clinical language a teacher should not be applying to a child
- Anything a student could not opt out of without being noticed

Then tell me:

- The single element most likely to harm a child who is already struggling
- Whether this activity should be run by me at all

Be direct. Good intentions are not the standard here.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- If it says this is not yours to run, take that seriously.
- Can a student opt out invisibly?

MORNING MEETINGS

CM-020 Plan a 10-minute morning meeting with a clear community goal

Grades K-2, 3-5

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Ten minutes that set the day, rather than filling it.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Plan a 10-minute morning meeting for [GRADE].

This week's focus: [WHAT YOU WANT TO BUILD]

Give me:

- A greeting that works for [NUMBER] students in the time available
- A share prompt about something students choose, never about home or feelings
- A short activity, 2-3 minutes, needing no materials
- The closing line that sends them into the day
- Realistic timing – greetings take longer than anyone plans

Rules:

- Every part is joinable by a student who does not want to speak
- No prompt about family, home, weekend, holidays, possessions or feelings
- No student is the focus unless they chose to be

Then tell me what to cut when the meeting has to be six minutes.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does any prompt touch home, money, or family?
- Can a silent student take part?

CM-021 Create inclusive check-in options that do not force disclosure

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Checking in without requiring anyone to perform being fine.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Design check-in options for a [GRADE] class that do not require disclosure.

Give me:

- 4 ways a student can check in, including at least one entirely non-verbal and one that involves no signal at all
- What I actually learn from each, honestly
- How a student signals they want to talk later, privately
- What I do with what I notice, and what I do not do with it
- How I avoid a check-in becoming a public mood display

Rules:

- No mood charts, colour cards, or anything the class can see
- No question requiring a student to say they are not fine in order to be heard
- Opting out must be invisible and unremarkable
- I am not collecting data on children's emotional states

Then tell me what a check-in cannot tell me, so I do not read too much into it.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is opting out genuinely invisible?
- What are you doing with what you notice? Decide before you start.

CM-022 Build a weekly morning-meeting sequence without repetitive prompts

Grades K-2, 3-5

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Five days that build, rather than five days of the same question.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Plan five morning meetings for [GRADE], 10 minutes each, threaded around [THEME].

Give me:

- Five days, each with a greeting, a share prompt, and a short activity
- How Friday connects back to Monday, so the week is one thing
- Prompts that vary in kind, not just in wording – one about noticing, one about choosing, one about explaining
- The day most likely to fall flat, and the backup for it

Rules:

- No prompt about home, family, feelings, possessions or weekend activities
- Nothing requiring a student to speak
- No prompt that a student who has had a bad morning cannot answer

Then give me the three prompts I could reuse in any week, so I always have something ready.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Do the five genuinely differ in kind?
- Could a student having a bad morning answer each one?

SEATING AND GROUPING

CM-023 Create a seating plan from classroom access and learning constraints

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A plan built on needs, not on who annoys whom.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a seating plan for [GRADE] [SUBJECT].

Room: [LAYOUT, NUMBER OF DESKS, WHERE THE BOARD AND DOOR ARE]

Class size: [NUMBER]

Constraints, described as needs not students: [e.g. two students need to be near the front for vision, one needs a clear exit route, three should not be adjacent]

Give me:

- The plan, described so I could draw it
- Why each constrained position is where it is
- How the plan looks unremarkable, so no seat reads as a designation
- What I say when a student asks why they are sitting there
- What changes when two students are absent

Rules:

- No student named or described in a way that identifies them
- No seat that is visibly the special seat, the front-for-behaviour seat, or the isolation seat
- Everyone can see the board and reach the door

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Does any seat read as a designation?
- Can everyone genuinely see and exit?

CM-024 Build a transparent regrouping plan using temporary learning evidence

Grades 3-5, 6-8, 9-12

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Groups that change, and are seen to change.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a regrouping plan for [GRADE] [SUBJECT] based on this evidence:

[DESCRIBE THE LEARNING PATTERNS – no names]

Give me:

- The groups, defined by what they are working on rather than by level
- What I tell students about why groups change, in one sentence
- How often groups change, and what triggers a change
- How a student moves group without it being an event
- The evidence I gather that would move someone

Rules:

- Groups are named after the work, not after a level or an animal that everyone decodes within a week
- No group is permanent, and the plan states when they end
- No student stays in the same group all term by default

Then tell me the sign that these have quietly become fixed ability groups.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Is there a stated end date?
- Would the class decode the group names?

CM-025 Audit seating and grouping decisions for labels, isolation and accessibility

All grades

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Before the arrangement becomes permanent by inertia.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Audit this [GRADE] seating and grouping arrangement: [DESCRIBE IT]

Tell me:

- Whether any seat or group is identifiable as being for a particular kind of student
- Whether anyone is isolated – physically apart, or the only one of something
- Whether every student can see, hear, reach the door, and access materials
- Whether the arrangement is doing what it was set up to do, or is just habit
- Whether any student has been in the same position or group all term
- What a student in the least desirable position would say about it

Then tell me:

- The one change that would most improve it
- Whether this arrangement should be rebuilt from scratch

Be direct about anything that isolates a child, however practical the reason.

BEFORE YOU SEND IT

- Answer the "least desirable position" question honestly yourself.
- When did you last change it?